The Training Compass

Discover your training path.

EDUCATIONAL GUIDE

Welcome: training should meet you where you are

You do not need to be fit before you begin. You do not need to know every exercise, own expensive equipment or follow the hardest workout you can find. You need a sensible starting point and a way to progress.

The Training Compass helps you understand common training methods, clarify what you want, consider what you can currently do, and choose a direction you are more likely to enjoy and sustain.

This guide is educational. It does not diagnose medical conditions, replace a qualified health professional, or provide an individualized exercise prescription. Your answers and self-assessment can help identify a preliminary direction; a coach should review relevant details before designing a personal program.

How to use this guide

Read the guide once to understand the training landscape. Then complete the companion Training Compass Workbook. Be honest rather than trying to achieve a particular score. Your starting point is information, not a judgment.

The process has five steps:

1. Explore training methods that are realistically accessible.
2. Identify your main goal and any secondary goals.
3. Understand your current physical starting point.
4. Identify the activities you enjoy, your practical constraints and your recovery needs.
5. Build a preliminary direction and decide what needs further assessment.

You can repeat the workbook after a period of consistent training to notice changes. A reassessment is a chance to adjust, not a test you must pass.

1. Understand the training landscape

People often use the words sport, discipline, exercise and training method as if they mean the same thing. They are related, but not identical.

A discipline is an organized activity, such as running or powerlifting. A training method is an approach used to develop a quality, such as hypertrophy training or interval training. A physical quality is an ability, such as strength, endurance, mobility or power.

Many activities develop several qualities at once. Calisthenics can develop strength, coordination, muscular endurance and skill. Running develops endurance but also places repeated demands on muscles, tendons and joints. CrossFit-style training combines several methods; its effects depend on the programming.

This guide focuses on options that can be practiced in a conventional gym, at home or in accessible public spaces, with running, cycling and swimming included as endurance options. It does not attempt to cover every sport or specialized sporting environment.

2. Five training families

The families below are a practical map, not rigid boxes. There is overlap between them, and the same exercise can serve different purposes depending on how it is programmed.

Training family	Examples	What it can develop	Considerations
Resistance training	General strength, bodybuilding/hypertrophy, powerlifting	Muscle size, strength, bone and connective-tissue loading capacity when appropriately progressed	Technique, load selection, volume and recovery matter.
Bodyweight training	Calisthenics, weighted calisthenics/streetlifting, gymnastics-inspired strength exercises	Relative strength, control, coordination, muscular endurance and skills	Some progressions are demanding; use scaled variations and adequate preparation.
Hybrid and functional training	CrossFit-style training, functional fitness, circuits	A combination of strength, conditioning, coordination and work capacity	The label alone does not define intensity. Programming and scaling are essential.
Conditioning training	HIIT, interval training, Insanity-style sessions	Cardiorespiratory fitness and the ability to repeat demanding efforts	High intensity is not a requirement for fitness. Beginners need appropriate doses.
Endurance training	Running, cycling, swimming	Aerobic capacity, endurance and the ability to sustain activity	Progress duration and workload gradually; technique and access vary by activity.

Resistance training: building strength and muscle

Resistance training makes muscles work against an external load or bodyweight. The resistance may come from machines, dumbbells, barbells, cables, bands or bodyweight.

General strength training develops the ability to produce force. Hypertrophy-focused training is organized to stimulate muscle growth. Bodybuilding is a sport and training approach strongly focused on muscular development and physique. Powerlifting is a strength sport centered on the squat, bench press and deadlift; its training methods can also be used by recreational trainees.

You do not need to compete in bodybuilding or powerlifting to benefit from their training principles. A beginner can start with stable, manageable movements and learn technique before progressing to heavier loads.

> **Useful questions:** Do you want to become stronger? Build muscle? Improve confidence with gym equipment? Do you prefer a structured routine or variety?

Bodyweight training: strength and control

Calisthenics uses bodyweight movements and progressions to develop strength, control, coordination and skills. Common exercises include push-ups, rows, pull-ups, dips, squats, lunges, hanging work and core exercises.

A person does not need to perform a pull-up or advanced skill to begin. Push-ups can be made easier by using a wall or elevated surface. Rows can be adjusted by changing body angle or using an appropriate machine or suspension setup. Squats can be supported or performed to a comfortable range.

Streetlifting generally refers to weighted calisthenics, often adding external load to movements such as pull-ups and dips. It is a more specialized progression, not a starting requirement.

Calisthenics can be practiced in a gym, at home or in suitable outdoor spaces. It can complement resistance training: external weights can help train muscles or movement patterns that are difficult to load progressively with bodyweight alone.

Hybrid and functional training: combining qualities

Hybrid training combines different forms of training, often resistance work and endurance. Functional fitness generally uses movements intended to develop useful physical capacities such as lifting, carrying, pushing, pulling, squatting, stepping and moving with control.

CrossFit is a branded training system and community built around varied functional movements performed at different intensities. A CrossFit-style workout may include strength, gymnastics-inspired movements, conditioning and technical exercises. It should not be reduced to ‘just cardio’.

Circuit training arranges exercises into a sequence, with planned work and rest. A circuit can be gentle or extremely demanding. The exercises, pace, rounds and rest periods determine the actual training effect.

These approaches can be motivating for people who enjoy variety or group sessions. They also require appropriate scaling. A beginner does not need maximal effort, complex lifts or high-impact repetitions to benefit from a circuit.

Conditioning: developing work capacity

Conditioning describes training intended to improve the ability to perform and recover from physical effort. HIIT uses repeated periods of relatively hard work separated by recovery. Interval training is a broader term and can include moderate or vigorous efforts. Insanity-style programs are examples of high-energy, interval-based bodyweight conditioning.

Not every interval session is HIIT, and not every conditioning session needs to be intense. Walking intervals, easy cycling intervals or short controlled circuits may be more appropriate starting points for some people.

High intensity can create substantial fatigue. It should be introduced in proportion to current capacity, experience, health considerations and recovery. More intensity is not automatically more progress.

Endurance: running, cycling and swimming

Endurance training develops the ability to sustain physical activity over time. Running, cycling and swimming are the endurance activities included in this guide.

Running is accessible in many places and requires relatively little equipment, but it involves repeated impact. Beginners can alternate comfortable walking and jogging, or start with walking if that is the appropriate level.

Cycling can be performed outdoors or on a stationary bike. It allows people to adjust resistance and pace, and may be a useful option for those who prefer lower-impact aerobic activity. Bike fit and safe riding conditions matter.

Swimming provides aerobic exercise with buoyancy and reduced weight-bearing impact, but access to a pool and basic water competence are necessary. This guide does not teach swimming technique; people who need instruction should seek a qualified swimming professional.

Endurance training can complement resistance training. The right balance depends on goals, volume, intensity, scheduling and recovery.

3. What do you want your training to do?

Choose one primary goal and, if useful, one or two secondary goals. A primary goal helps determine what receives the most attention. Secondary goals can shape complementary training without competing for all your time and recovery.

Common goal profiles:

- **Muscle development:** increase muscle size and muscular development.
- **Strength development:** improve the amount of force you can produce.
- **Bodyweight mastery:** build the strength and control needed for movements such as push-ups, pull-ups, dips and later skills.
- **Endurance:** improve your ability to sustain running, cycling or swimming.
- **General fitness:** improve several physical qualities for everyday life and recreation.
- **Fat-loss support:** improve activity, fitness and muscle retention while nutrition and energy balance are addressed.
- **Hybrid development:** improve strength and endurance together.

Goals can change. Someone may begin by wanting to lose fat and later prioritize strength, or begin with general fitness and discover a passion for calisthenics.

4. Your physical starting point: readiness, not body type

People often describe themselves as overweight, average, skinny, unfit or athletic. Body size alone does not tell us what a person can do. A person with a larger body may be strong and experienced; a thin person may have excellent endurance; someone with an average body size may have limited strength or exercise tolerance.

For that reason, the Training Compass uses functional readiness rather than body shape as its main starting-point lens.

> **Foundation & Adaptation:** basic activity or exercise currently feels difficult, or the person is new or returning after a long break. The priority is comfortable movement, basic patterns, confidence, consistency and gradual tolerance.

> **General Development:** the person can complete basic workouts but has limited strength, endurance, technique or ability to sustain demanding sessions. The priority is balanced development and progressive training.

> **Strength & Capacity Development:** the person already tolerates regular exercise but wants to develop more muscle, strength or work capacity. The priority is structured resistance training and progressive overload, with conditioning and other methods chosen to support the goal.

These are broad descriptions, not medical categories or permanent labels. A person can have different readiness levels across strength, endurance and movement. The workbook records those dimensions separately.

5. Assess your capabilities without turning it into a competition

A useful baseline is repeatable, safe and relevant. It does not need to be a maximal test. Do not test through pain, dizziness, chest discomfort, unusual breathlessness or other concerning symptoms. Stop if you feel unwell. If you have a relevant medical condition, injury, significant symptoms or uncertainty about exercise safety, seek advice from an appropriate health professional before testing or beginning a program.

The workbook uses simple observations:

- **Push pattern:** a wall or elevated push-up variation, if comfortable.
- **Pull pattern:** a supported or machine row, if available and familiar.
- **Lower-body pattern:** a comfortable sit-to-stand or squat variation.
- **Trunk control:** a comfortable, brief plank variation only if appropriate.
- **Aerobic tolerance:** how you feel during an easy walk or other familiar moderate activity.
- **Movement comfort:** whether basic shoulder, hip and ankle movements feel comfortable.

Do not compare your result with another person's. Record the variation, support, range of motion and perceived effort so that you can compare your own future performance fairly. A single repetition count cannot determine your overall fitness.

6. Preference is part of the plan

A plan that looks ideal on paper may fail if the person dislikes it, feels intimidated by it or cannot fit it into daily life. Enjoyment does not replace sound programming, but it can make consistency more realistic.

Ask yourself:

- Which activities genuinely attract me?
- Which would I voluntarily do again?
- Do I prefer a gym, home or outdoor setting?
- Do I enjoy structure and repetition, or variety?
- Do I prefer training alone or with other people?
- Which activities would I rather avoid?

If you like calisthenics but are not yet ready for full push-ups, start with an appropriate progression. If you enjoy running but currently have low tolerance, begin with manageable walking or walk-jog intervals. If you dislike running, cycling or swimming may offer another route to aerobic development.

The preference helps choose the direction; current readiness helps determine the starting level.

7. Build a combination: primary, complementary and optional

A practical routine does not need to contain every training method. Use three roles:

> **Primary method:** the training approach most directly connected to your main goal. Examples: resistance training for muscle development, calisthenics for bodyweight strength, running for a running goal.

> **Complementary method:** supports the primary method or develops a quality that the primary method does not fully address. Examples: resistance training alongside running; mobility drills alongside calisthenics; easy cycling alongside a strength program.

> **Optional method:** an activity added only if it fits your capacity, preferences and recovery. Examples: a short conditioning circuit or an additional easy aerobic session.

Examples of combinations:

- Calisthenics + resistance training + easy cycling.
- Resistance training + running + basic mobility.
- Running + resistance training + walking.
- CrossFit-style sessions + easy aerobic work + mobility drills.
- Bodybuilding-focused resistance training + calisthenics skills.
- Cycling + resistance training.

These are examples, not prescriptions. CrossFit, HIIT and other demanding conditioning sessions can overlap with strength training and create substantial fatigue. Schedule them carefully rather than simply adding more work.

8. A simple weekly structure

Your schedule should fit your availability and current capacity. Two well-managed sessions can be more useful than a six-day plan that you cannot sustain.

Illustrative starting structures:

- **Foundation:** 2–3 manageable activity days, with rest or easy movement between sessions as needed.
- **General development:** 3–4 sessions combining resistance work and manageable aerobic activity.
- **Established recreational trainee:** 4–5 or more sessions only if training history, workload and recovery support it.

A sample four-day general-development week:

Monday	full-body resistance training.
Tuesday	easy walk, cycling or swimming.
Wednesday	rest or comfortable mobility drills.
Thursday	full-body resistance training.
Friday	rest or easy movement.
Saturday	preferred endurance activity or a manageable conditioning session.
Sunday	rest.

This is an example calendar, not a requirement. Training days can be moved. The appropriate number of sessions depends on the person, the content of each session and recovery.

9. Progress gradually

Progress is not only adding weight or making a workout harder. You can progress by improving technique, increasing comfortable range of motion, adding a small amount of resistance, completing a planned repetition, increasing duration, improving consistency or needing less assistance.

The main training variables include:

- **Frequency:** how often you train.
- **Volume:** how much work you complete.
- **Intensity:** how demanding the work is.
- **Complexity:** how technically challenging the movement is.
- **Density:** how much work is completed within a given time.

Avoid increasing all variables at once. Change one or a small number of variables, then observe how you respond.

A useful review rhythm is every 4–6 weeks, although the timing is flexible. Ask: Have I trained consistently? Is technique improving? Is the workload manageable? Am I recovering? Do I still enjoy the activity? Does the plan still match my goal?

If performance drops, fatigue accumulates or discomfort appears, more work may not be the answer. Reduce or modify the workload and seek professional guidance when needed.

10. Mobility as a supporting practice

Mobility is included as a supporting component, not as a separate yoga or Pilates offering. Simple, comfortable drills may help people practice controlled movement through ranges they use in training.

Examples include:

- Shoulder circles or controlled shoulder rotations.
- Wall slides for comfortable shoulder movement.
- Hip rotations or controlled 90/90 transitions.
- Ankle knee-to-wall movements.
- Gentle thoracic rotations.
- Controlled leg swings.
- Comfortable dynamic movement preparation before exercise.

Choose drills relevant to the session and your current movement ability. Move smoothly and stay within a comfortable range. Do not force a stretch, bounce aggressively or treat pain as a sign that the drill is working.

Mobility work does not guarantee prevention of soreness or injury. Training load, gradual progression, sleep, recovery and technique all matter. Persistent pain or significant movement restrictions should be assessed by an appropriate professional.

11. Nutrition and recovery: the support system

Training is only one part of physical development. Nutrition, sleep, stress and recovery influence how well you adapt.

For general education:

- Energy intake influences body-weight change over time.
- Protein supports repair and adaptation of muscle tissue; needs vary with body size, activity, goals and health.
- Carbohydrates provide useful energy for many forms of training.
- Dietary fats and a varied diet support normal body functions.
- Hydration needs vary with climate, activity duration, sweat rate and individual factors.
- Sleep and rest support recovery and performance.

Avoid assuming that everyone needs supplements, a mass gainer, a strict meal plan or a specific diet. Individual nutrition advice, medical nutrition therapy, supplement decisions involving health conditions or medications, and assessment of suspected deficiencies should be referred to an appropriately qualified health professional or registered nutrition professional. This guide is not a diet plan.

12. Your preliminary Training Compass profile

After completing the workbook, summarize:

1. Primary goal and secondary goals.
2. Functional starting profile.
3. Your current strengths and the areas you want to develop.
4. Preferred training method and activities you want to avoid.
5. Available days, time, equipment and training location.
6. A primary method and one complementary method to explore.
7. Questions, limitations or uncertainties that need a conversation or professional assessment.

The result is a starting direction, not a finished program. A coach should clarify technique, exercise selection, training volume, intensity, progression and relevant limitations before providing an individualized plan.

A note about coaching and scope

A self-assessment cannot diagnose injury, assess medical readiness, or replace observation of exercise technique. A questionnaire can miss important context. Do not use this guide to self-treat pain or medical conditions.

A qualified coach can help translate your preliminary profile into an appropriate training plan within their competence. Where the person’s needs fall outside that scope — for example, rehabilitation, persistent pain, medical exercise clearance, swimming instruction or specialized technical coaching — refer to the relevant qualified professional.

The purpose of the Training Compass is to make the first conversation more informed, not to pretend that a form can replace professional judgment.

Your next step

You do not need to have everything figured out today. Start by identifying what matters to you, what you can currently do and what kind of activity you are willing to practice consistently.

Complete the companion workbook. Bring your profile to a qualified coach if you want help turning it into a structured plan.

Understand your starting point. Choose a direction. Build from there.